



DARING GREATLY

How the Courage to be Vulnerable Transforms the Way We Live, Love, Parent and Lead

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The Big “So What”

As human beings, we have a fundamental need for connection, love, and belonging. Yet, we fear rejection and are afraid we’re not good enough. We try to hide our vulnerabilities, only to create a greater disconnect with our families, communities, and work. Based on 12 years of research, [this book explains the concept of vulnerability, and how to embrace it for wholehearted living and fulfilling connections.](#)



Introduction

Having worked and researched widely on the constructs of human connection, Brown discovered that vulnerability is one of the most powerful explanations for human behaviour. In the book, Brown explains vulnerability and shame, and why embracing (rather than avoiding) them is the key to more fulfilling connections. [Daring greatly is about embracing vulnerability and imperfection, to live wholeheartedly and engage courageously.](#)

[In this summary, we’ve consolidated the ideas into 4 parts: understanding vulnerability, managing shame, removing the armour, and closing the gap.](#)



Part 1: Understanding Vulnerability

A Culture of Scarcity



[Most of us live in cultures of scarcity or “never enough”. We’re constantly measuring and comparing what we have, against what we want, what we don’t have, what others have, or even how things used to be. We long for connection and belonging, yet we’re afraid of being unworthy if we don’t live up to a standard or ideal.](#)

KEY QUOTES

“Vulnerability is the core, the heart, the center, of meaningful experiences.”

“Social work (is not) about fixing... (it) is all about leaning into the discomfort of ambiguity and uncertainty, and holding an emphatic space so people can find their own way.”

“If we’re willing to dare greatly and risk vulnerability with each other, worthiness has the power to set us free.”

“The bottom line is that daring greatly requires worthiness.”

Many of our deepest insecurities involve being not smart enough, not loveable enough, not successful enough, not slim enough, etc.

There are **3 key components of scarcity**:

 **Shame:** When we measure our self-worth by how much we achieve, earn, produce, conform, etc., or when we use fear (of rejection, humiliation etc.) to control or manipulate others.

 **Comparison:** When we compare and evaluate people based on a fixed yardstick, rather than appreciate them for their uniqueness.

 **Disengagement:** When people avoid taking risks and speaking up, or when they compete for attention (to be seen or heard).

When you examine these components, you'd realize **the opposite of scarcity is not abundance, but "enough"**. When you feel you're good enough regardless of what you do (or don't do), you'll dare to engage despite uncertainty and emotional risks. Brown calls this "wholeheartedness".

When we remove labels and stereotypes, to see people through the lenses of vulnerability, we start to understand the real struggles beneath their actions. For example, people complain that the younger generation is becoming increasingly self-centred and obsessed with social media. From the perspective of vulnerability, many of these kids have been influenced by reality TV and celebrity culture to believe that they're only as good as the number of followers or "likes" they have; they're simply trying to feel special in a world of "never enough".

Debunking the Vulnerability Myths



To understand vulnerability, it helps to understand what it is not.

 **Vulnerability is not Weakness.**

- **Vulnerability is merely a feeling of being "naked", a sense of uncertainty and emotional exposure.** This is an inevitable part of life, and there's nothing good or bad about it. When we associate vulnerability with weakness, we try to avoid it and hide our feelings as a mistaken sign of strength. For example, love is uncertain; yet, avoiding love to escape vulnerability makes life meaningless.

KEY QUOTES

"The greatest casualties of a scarcity culture are our willingness to own our vulnerabilities and our ability to engage with the world from a place of worthiness."

"The one thing we have in common is that we're sick of being afraid. We all want to be brave. We want to dare greatly."

"Sometimes the simple act of humanizing problems sheds an important light on them, a light that often goes out the minute a stigmatizing label is applied."

"We've confused feeling with failing and emotions with liabilities."

"Truth and courage aren't always comfortable, but they're never weakness."

- In fact, things that make you feel vulnerable - e.g. doing something controversial, or saying “sorry” - are typically associated with courage and truth (not weakness). We see others’ vulnerability as courage, but condemn our own as weakness. We want others to be open and accessible to us, yet we’re afraid to be open and accessible.
- Instead of asking yourself, “What would I attempt to do if I knew I could not fail?”, Brown challenges you to ask, “What’s worth doing even if I fail?”



Vulnerability is not an Option. People may claim they don’t “do vulnerability” because they are strong, logical, professional etc. However, vulnerability is not a choice – life itself is unpredictable, and we all feel unsure and exposed at times. The key is how we respond to vulnerability.



Vulnerability is not Letting It All Out. Embracing vulnerability is not about baring your soul to everyone. It’s about opening up to people with whom you’ve cultivated a strong, trusting relationship, to share with reciprocity, trust and boundaries. Building such relationships takes time, and Brown likens it to a filling a jar with marbles:

- We add marbles when people demonstrate that they care. They share their secrets and keep ours; they remember what matters to us, involve us when things go well, and show concern when we face challenges.
- We remove marbles when the opposite happens. In fact, when those closest to us start to become disengaged, we feel hurt because it triggers our feelings of shame, unworthiness and fear of abandonment. The entire jar can be shattered in the event of a major betrayal, e.g. when someone uses your secret against you.
- Building trust is a chicken-and-egg situation: you’d want to feel trust before showing vulnerability, but you must be willing to be vulnerable to gain trust.



Vulnerability isn’t best tackled alone. Most cultures value the ability to solve problems independently. However, the best way to handle vulnerability is with support from others. Research shows that, when someone is willing to be vulnerable, others

KEY QUOTES

“We love seeing raw truth and openness in other people, but we’re afraid to let them see it in us.”

“Often the result of daring greatly isn’t a victory march as much as it is a quiet sense of freedom mixed with a little battle fatigue.”

“When the people we love or with whom we have a deep connection stop caring, stop paying attention, stop investing, and stop fighting for the relationship, trust begins to slip away and hurt starts seeping in.”

“Sometimes our first and greatest dare is asking for support.”

perceive it to be courageous, and gradually open up too.
Courage is contagious.



Part 2: Understanding and Managing Shame

What is Shame?



Shame is the agonizing feeling that we're flawed and hence unworthy of love and belonging. All of us experience shame, everyone is afraid to talk about it, and our silence only gives it even more power. Shame is different from guilt, humiliation and embarrassment, because we see the flaw as a part of who we are.

- You feel **guilt** when you think you've *done* something wrong ("how could I do that?"). Your actions seem incongruent with who you are, and you're likely to apologize or make amends.
- You feel **humiliated** when you feel you don't *deserve* a negative outcome ("they have no right to do this").
- **Embarrassment** is the least severe and will usually pass quickly.

Shame is different, because you feel you're bad as a person ("I'm such a loser"), and you *deserve the bad outcomes*. Research shows that shame is correlated only with negative outcomes, like violence, aggression, or depression.

Building Shame Resilience



We can't avoid or remove shame from our lives, but we can become more resilient to it. There are **4 key elements** of shame resilience:



Recognize shame. Let's imagine you're writing a book and feel unsure about finishing it. As you look deeper, you notice a voice telling you that you're a lousy writer, and another one saying you'll be a laughing stock. Brown calls them your "gremlins". *Learn to identify shame and its triggers* - know and acknowledge when you're feeling shame, and start to understand your own self-doubts and self-criticisms.



Evaluate expectations. *Identify the judgments behind the shame*, which are often linked to social and cultural expectations.

KEY QUOTES

"Shame derives its power from being unspeakable."

"Shame is the fear of disconnection – the fear that we're unlovable and don't belong."

"When our self-worth isn't on the line, we are far more willing to be courageous and risk sharing our raw talents and gifts."

- Brown's research revealed 12 key categories of shame: appearance & body image, money & work, family, parenting, fatherhood/motherhood, mental & physical health, addiction, sex, aging, religion, past trauma, and being stereotyped/labelled.
- Assess if the expectations are realistic and aligned with your values. For example, is it realistic to have a best-selling book on your first attempt? Are you really a failure if your book isn't popular? Taking a step back to think about your shame helps you to break the fight-or-flight response.



Get connected. Reach out to someone you trust. Once you feel their empathy and connection, your shame (which is the fear of disconnection) will dissolve.



Share it. Shame cannot survive once it's exposed. Don't be afraid to speak about your fears and ask for support. Research shows that people who suffer past trauma recover much better when they use expressive writing or share their stories with others.

Once, Brown received an angry email from someone whom she'd refused a speaking engagement. Feeling upset, she wrote an email to her husband to vent, but accidentally clicked "send" instead of "forward". She was drowning in shame when the other party replied to point out her lack of wholeheartedness.

- Using the elements above, she said "pain, pain, pain, pain" aloud to acknowledge her feelings, until she felt better.
- Then, she called her husband and best friend, and instantly felt reassured by their empathy and love. She also spoke kindly to herself, the same way she would've comforted someone else.
- When she was feeling calmer, she wrote a reply to apologize to the other party and set boundaries for future communications.

Understanding Gender Differences



While shame affects both genders equally, social-cultural expectations create different shame triggers and responses for men vs women:

KEY QUOTES

"A sense of worthiness inspires us to be vulnerable, share openly, and persevere. Shame keeps us small, resentful, and afraid."

"Empathy is connection; it's a ladder out of the shame hole".

"Shame is universal, but the messages and expectations that drive shame are organized by gender."



Women expect themselves to look naturally beautiful, slim, be good at everything (especially motherhood), and to seem to do it all effortlessly. They feel shame when they're not beautiful enough, can't multi-task well enough, etc. When shamed, women intuitively respond by *criticizing or putting others down*, in an unconscious attempt to draw attention away from their inadequacies.



Men on the other hand, must never be weak – they must control their feelings, earn more, take charge, and succeed in their careers. When they feel shame, men naturally *get angry or shut down*.



Men and women also attach shame differently to **sex and body image**. Women are conscious of their bodies, and interpret men's lack of interest to mean they're not slim, attractive or experienced enough. Men, on the other hand, are more concerned if their partners care about them, and see rejection as a form of masculine shame that they're not wanted, or not good enough.



Shame can tear a relationship apart, and gender differences amplify the strain:

- **Downward spirals**. When women feel invalidated, they start criticizing, which triggers men's feeling of inadequacy. The men get angry or shut down, causing women to provoke them even more ("why won't you talk to me!").
- **Entrenched gender expectations**. Women want their men to open up and let them in. Yet, most women can't really accept vulnerability in their men (who're supposed to be strong). When women react with disappointment or even disgust, it reinforces the men's shame and resolve not to show weakness again.
- **Security breach**. Shame is most painful when it comes from those closest to us. Using a loved one's vulnerability to shame him/her is the most severe breach of trust and can cause permanent scars in the relationship.

Cultivating Whole heartedness



Using the 4 elements of shame resilience, we can build our self-worth and wholeheartedness:

KEY QUOTES

"It's not the lack of professing that gets us in trouble in our relationships; it's failing to practice love that leads to hurt."



Practicing **self-love** is one of the best ways to nurture courage, self-worth, and our ability to love others. When we feel worthy, we're less likely to judge or criticize others.



As you build awareness of societal/ cultural expectations, you can identify shame when it surfaces, evaluate it and make a **conscious decision** not to play the game. For example, you may realize that missing your child's concert for a work trip does not mean you're a bad mother, and you can learn to love yourself and others for who you really are, rather than what society expects of you.



Practice love by trusting and being vulnerable with your loved ones, and supporting them in their vulnerabilities. The next time you see someone struggling with a shameful situation, instead of passing judgement, take the initiative to **extend your empathy** with a smile or understanding look. This small gesture may help them to feel instantly better.



Part 3: Removing the Armour

Everyone struggles with vulnerability (including Brown), and we put on different persona or masks to protect ourselves. Even children put on masks, though these are more fleeting and easier to detect. The school bully could simply be masking his need to belong, while the mean girl could be hiding the pain from her parents' divorce.

Since shame is the feeling of not being enough, **simply believing that we're "enough" helps us to remove our masks**. In this segment, we'll explain the key types of armour and how to remove them.

3 Common Vulnerability Shields



Foreboding joy is the feeling that your joyful experiences (e.g. getting a promotion, falling in love) are too good to be true. You keep expecting the next disaster to strike and constantly plan for the worst. The solution is to **practice gratitude**: focus on what you're grateful for, including the small, ordinary moments like being healthy, or having your loved ones by your side.



Perfectionism is about trying to be perfect to avoid failure or shame. It's different from a healthy pursuit of excellence, and only brings more shame, as you're never perfect enough. The cure is to **learn to see the beauty of imperfection**: Be kind to

KEY QUOTES

"If we want to fully experience love and belonging, we must believe that we are worthy of love and belonging."

"To love ourselves and support each other in the process of becoming real is perhaps the greatest single act of daring greatly."

"Connection is the energy that is created between people when they feel seen, heard, and valued; when they can give and receive without judgement."

"Masks make us feel safer even when they become suffocating."

"Believing that we're 'enough' is the way out of the armor – it gives us permission to take off the mask."

"When we lose the ability or willingness to be vulnerable, joy becomes something we approach with deep foreboding."

*"There's a crack in everything. That's how the light gets in."
- Leonard Cohen*

yourself when you fail or suffer (rather than avoid/ condemn it), realize that everyone feels pain and inadequacy, and practice mindfulness to separate your fleeting thoughts and feelings from who you really are.



People also use busy-ness to numb themselves. Outwardly, they take pride in being available 24x7 to their clients, never dropping the ball, etc. But, under the busy-ness is a sense of insecurity: women are afraid to say no and not please everyone, while men are afraid they're not "man enough" to handle everything.

- The antidote is to set boundaries, e.g. no work calls after 10pm. Cultivate self-worth based on who you are, not what you do. When you stop trying to satisfy everyone, you can focus on the people and things that truly matter.
- Brown's research reveals that a deep sense of connectedness (or spirituality) is a core aspect of wholehearted living. This is about the manner and intent in which you go about your daily life, e.g. if you're enjoying your meal or just gulping it down, if you're seeing and connecting with the people you meet (e.g. the cashier, the waiter) or just treating them as objects in the background.

Other Masks and Armours



Other less commonly-used shields include:



Classifying people/things into win-lose extremes, e.g. success vs failures, kill or be killed. People with such shields avoid vulnerability, leading to more disconnection. It's especially common in the military, or in people who've suffered trauma (e.g. physical abuse, oppression). The solution is to redefine success, and use the 4 shame resilience components to restore one's ability to face vulnerability.



Letting loose, either using vulnerability to manipulate/ seek attention, or releasing all your vulnerability on someone without deep trust/ connectivity. In such cases, people may withdraw from you to cause even more shame. Get clear on your intentions, consider your feelings and desired outcomes, and manage your boundaries and connections accordingly.



"Serpenting", or spending undue amounts of energy to zig-zag around vulnerability, when it's less effortful to face

KEY QUOTES

"We can't selectively numb emotion. Numb the dark and you numb the light."

"Living a connected life ultimately is about... spending less time and energy hustling and winning over people who don't matter, and... cultivating connection with family and close friends."

"It's not what you do; it's why you do it that makes the difference."
-Louden

"When we feel good about the choices we're making and when we're engaging with the world from a place of worthiness rather than scarcity, we feel no need to judge and attack."

it directly. Cultivate awareness, so you can catch and stop yourself from serpentine.



We **judge** others whenever we label them as inferior or dismiss them. Brown made a personal choice to stop worrying about bystanders who judge and complain from the sidelines. Instead, she only pays attention only to people who are “*in the arena*”, i.e. those who’re actively working on similar challenges, and people whom she loves and trusts most (and are always fighting by her side in the arena).



Part 4: Closing the Gap

The Disengagement Divide



People desire connection, yet they become disengaged when (a) they feel vulnerable, and/or (b) they feel that the other party isn’t fulfilling his/ her role in the social contract. In short, **this disengagement divide occurs because of the gap between our *aspired values* (what we want to do, think and feel) and our *practiced values* (what we actually do, think and feel).** For instance, children perceive a gap when their parents preach about honesty and respect, but lie or put each other down.

As humans, we can’t avoid such gaps; **the key is to become aware of them, and seek to close the gaps.** Brown believes that we must concurrently address our *strategy* (our game plan to get from where we are to where we want to be) and *culture* (the norms or ways things are typically done).

Rehumanizing Education and Work



Shame is a major barrier to creativity, innovation and learning in our education institutions and workplace. When shame is prevalent, people dare not speak up, try new things or persevere in face of failure.



Recognizing shame. Finger-pointing, gossiping, harassment and name-calling are all signs of shame in a culture.

- Shame can cause “*creativity scars*”- someone who’s told he/she is a lousy writer or hopeless leader can carry the self-doubts for life.

KEY QUOTES

“I... learned that the people who love me, the people I really depend on, were never the critics who were pointing at me while I stumbled... They were with me in the arena. Fighting for me and with me.”

“We need daring strategies to develop daring cultures.”

“To reignite creativity, innovation, and learning, leaders must rehumanize education and work.”

- Such practices spread, e.g. if employees constantly deal with shame at the workplace, they're likely to use similar behaviours with clients, suppliers and family members. It's worse when shame is used as a formal management or influencing tool, e.g. public ranking of top vs bottom performers, open criticisms.



Dealing with shame brings uncomfortable, dark issues to the light, and the process is both disruptive and irreversible. That's why Brown calls it "disruptive engagement". To build shame-resilient organizations:



Support leaders who're willing to dare greatly to facilitate honest conversations about shame. Since shame cannot survive in the open, and courage is contagious, people who're willing step forward to address shame are natural change catalysts. Such leaders can emerge at all levels in an organization.



Cultivate awareness of shame, so it can be identified and stopped immediately before it spreads.



"Normalize" shame and discomfort, so people realize such feelings are normal, and are less afraid to discuss their common struggles, coping strategies etc.



Train employees on the differences between shame and guilt, and how to give and receive constructive feedback.

- Use *strengths perspective* to facilitate feedback: for every area for improvement, identify 3 strengths that the other person has, to help him/ her make the change.
- Literally and figuratively sit on the *same side of the table* as someone, to focus your feedback on supporting him/her.
- Start by *inviting feedback*, so you learn what it's like to be on the receiving end, and role-play difficult situations.

Wholehearted Parenting



The best foundation we can give our children is a sense of love, belonging and self-worth.



Great parenting isn't about having the best strategies and techniques; it's about being the best-possible role models,

KEY QUOTES

"Shame breeds fear. It crushes our tolerance for vulnerability, thereby killing engagement, innovation, creativity, productivity, and trust."

"We all want to dare greatly. If you give us a glimpse into that possibility, we'll hold on to it as our vision. It can't be taken away."

"We can't give people what we don't have. Who we are matters immeasurably more than what we know or who we want to be."

"The simple and honest process of letting people know that discomfort is normal, it's going to happen, why it happens, and why it's important, reduces anxiety, fear, and shame."

"A daring greatly culture is a culture of honest, constructive and engaged feedback."

"If we're not willing to ask for feedback and receive it, we'll never be good at giving it."

given our own imperfections, i.e. **being the adults we want our children to be.**



Kids often don't feel they **belong** in their own families, as they feel they don't match up to their parents' expectations.

- Be conscious of the if-when rules that you're planting, e.g. do your kids feel loved only if they achieve certain grades, financial status, or behaviours? Do you unintentionally demonstrate that others' opinions are more important than what your kids feel?
- For children to feel worthy, they must feel loved just as they are. Let them know that you love them, even if you don't love their choices. Separate the child from his/ her behaviours, e.g. telling a lie doesn't make your child a liar, and tripping over something doesn't make him/her a klutz.



Rather than try to protect your children from shame, use such experiences to talk about shame and role-model shame resilience. Normalize shame by showing your children that everyone faces similar struggles. Teach your kids the difference between guilt vs shame when they're young (4-5 years old), and are still open and receptive.



Other Details in the Book to Look out For

Besides sharing the findings from her research and interviews, Brown re-enacts many of her exchanges with her audiences and interviewees, as well as her personal experiences and vulnerable moments. These help us to understand the often-unspoken vulnerabilities, insecurities and feelings that everyone has in one form or another.

In the book, Brown also includes her complete definitions of many concepts like love, connection, shame, as well as resources, checklists and manifestoes. Some of these resources are also available on her website www.brenebrown.com.

KEY QUOTES

"Who we are and how we engage with the world are much stronger predictors of how our children will do than what we know about parenting."

"If we want our children to love and accept who they are, our job is to love and accept who we are."

"Most of us struggle to feel a sense of belonging – to know that we're a part of something, not despite our vulnerabilities, but because of them."

"Wholehearted parenting is not having it all figured out and passing it down – it's learning and exploring together."

"What we know matters, but who we are matters more."